

Using Dialogs

Dialog windows (or dialog boxes, or just dialogs) are like alerts on steroids, or—if you'd rather think of things the other way around—alerts are stripped-down dialogs. The purpose of a dialog is allow the computer to carry on a kind of “conversation” with the user—that’s you. It’s a way for the computer to ask for information it needs to carry out one of your requests.

For an example, take a look at the Initialize dialog in Figure 5G. It shares some features with the alert we discussed in the last section. There’s a Caution icon (the black exclamation point in the yellow triangle) and the warning that the operation will cause all the information on the disk to be destroyed, and there are the buttons at the bottom of the window. (There’s also a line at the top of the window that tells you the name of the device that holds the disk you’re initializing.)

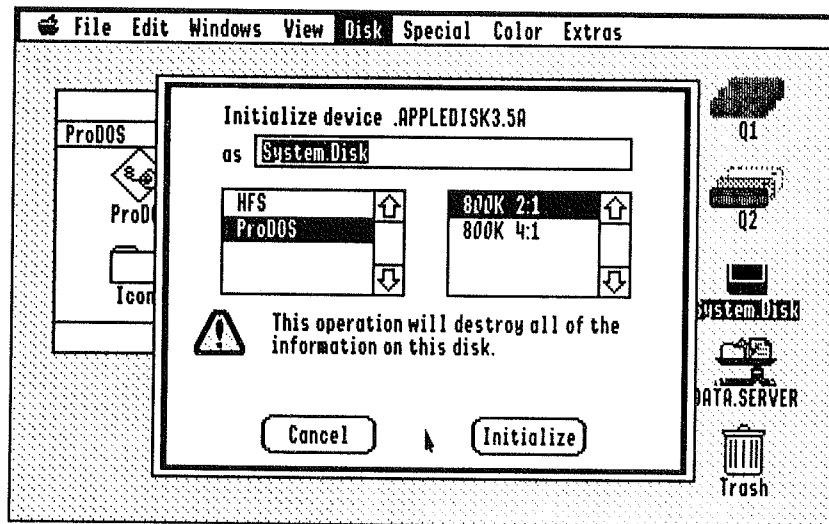


Figure 5G—Sample Dialog (Initialize, from Finder)

There are also three other boxes in the dialog. The topmost one is a place to enter your name for the disk you’re initializing. (This box is filled in with the disk’s current name or, if the disk is blank, with the default name of Untitled.) The box where you enter the disk’s name is called a line-edit field because it’s a place for entering and editing a single line of text; we’ll describe it in detail in a moment.

The two other boxes allow you to select what format the disk will be initialized with (either ProDOS or HFS, the Macintosh disk format) and the disk’s size and interleave. (We’ll leave a discussion of these terms for later.) These two boxes are called lists because they contain a list of your choices. To select one of the items in a list, simply click it. If there are more items in a list than will fit on the screen, you can use the scroll arrows next to the list to scroll the list up and down to reveal more of the items.